

CORE FORMULA

Hear the words -> identify the core meaning or feeling -> reflect it briefly -> pause for correction -> proceed. -> **Short form: notice -> name or respond -> invite -> calibrate -> release.** -> **So the main thing is that the plan changed after you'd already committed.** -> **It sounds like the frustrating part was the lack of warning.** -> **You wanted support, not someone solving it instantly.**

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Use one sentence: "So the main thing is..." or "It sounds like the frustrating part was..."

BEST FOR

- Emotionally loaded conversations
- Clarifying a disagreement before responding
- Supporting someone before offering advice
- Professional conversations where accuracy matters
- Calming a tense moment when someone feels unheard
- Checking you have understood before you decide or redirect

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Concise starters

- "So the main thing is..."
- "Sounds like the hard part was..."
- "So you wanted X, and got Y."
- "So the real issue is..."
- "It sounds like what mattered most was..."
- "So, underneath it, this is about..."
- "The bit that stung was..."

Warm / supporting · Support before advice

- "So the hard part wasn't just what happened, but how alone it felt."
- "It sounds like you were carrying a lot of uncertainty."
- "So you wanted support, not someone solving it instantly."
- "It sounds like that really knocked you about."
- "So more than anything, you just wanted to be heard."
- "It sounds like you've been holding this on your own for a while."
- "So the part that's staying with you is the way it ended."

Professional · Work and meetings

- "So the main concern is the decision process, not just the outcome."
- "It sounds like the bottleneck is clarity of ownership."
- "The issue is less the deadline and more the repeated change in scope."
- "So what you need before you commit is a clear owner."
- "It sounds like we're aligned on the timeline, but you want to revisit the budget."
- "So the risk you're flagging is that the scope keeps moving."
- "It sounds like the sticking point is who signs it off."

Checking understanding · Clarify and confirm

- "Let me check I've got this: the problem is the change, not the work itself."

- "So, in one line, this is about being reorganised without warning?"
- "Have I got the main thing right?"
- "So the ask is more notice, not less change — is that fair?"
- "Tell me if I'm off: the frustrating part is the unpredictability."
- "So the decision you actually want made is who owns it."
- "Is the core of it that you can't plan around them?"

Tentative / course-correcting · Leave room to be corrected

- "I might have this wrong, but it sounds like the timing is the real issue."
- "Correct me if I'm off — it seems the hard part was being left out."
- "Maybe the better way to say it is that you felt overlooked."
- "I don't want to put words in your mouth, but this sounds bigger than one meeting."
- "So, if I'm reading you right, it's less about the task and more about the trust."
- "Let me try that again — it sounds more like disappointment than anger."

Disagreement / pressure · Reflect before you respond

- "Before I respond, let me make sure I've understood your concern."
- "So the part you feel I'm missing is how much this has already cost you."
- "It sounds like this isn't really about the roster — it's about being able to plan your life."
- "So what you need me to get, before we go on, is that this keeps happening."
- "It sounds like you feel this has happened too many times to let slide."
- "So the thing that has to change for this to feel fair is the notice."

Digital / text · One-line reflections

- "Sounds like the frustrating part was the lack of warning."
- "So it felt like a sudden shift."
- "That reads like uncertainty more than disagreement."
- "So the main thing is the timing caught you off guard?"
- "Reading back — the hard bit was being left out of the call."
- "So, short version: you needed a heads-up you didn't get."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: I hear you. (Too generic to prove you actually understood.)
Better: You're annoyed because they changed the plan. (More specific, but stated too certainly.)
Best: It sounds like the frustrating part was the plan changing after you'd already committed. (Specific, tentative and grounded.)
2. Weak: Makes sense. (Vague; it could mean almost anything.)
Better: So you're worried about the deadline. (Names one thing, but maybe the wrong one.)
Best: So the real worry isn't the deadline itself — it's the scope changing under you. (Names the point beneath the words.)
3. Weak: That's rough. (Sympathy, but shows no understanding.)
Better: You're upset they let you down. (Assumes the feeling.)
Best: It sounds like the hard part wasn't just the let-down, but feeling you couldn't rely on them. (Tentative and specific.)

DECISION TREE

If They said something emotionally or practically important

Reflect the core in one line before moving on.

"So the main thing is that the plan changed after you'd committed."

If You are guessing beyond what they actually said

Make the reflection tentative so they can correct it.

"I might be reading this wrong, but it sounds like..."

If They correct your reflection

Accept the correction and update — the correction is a win.

"Got it — so it's more about the uncertainty than the change itself."

If They need action now, not reflection

Keep the reflection to one line, then move to the decision.

"So the priority is cover for tonight — let's sort that first."

If They shorten answers, tense up or redirect

Release the technique and follow the person.

"No worries — what would help most right now?"

SCENARIOS

A friend is upset

Reflect the hard part before offering any reassurance. — "So the worst bit was feeling you had no one to call."

A work conflict

Reflect the process concern before proposing a fix. — "So the sticking point is that scope keeps moving after we start."

A disagreement

Reflect their concern before you present your own view. — "So what matters most to you is that this stays fair to the team."

A clinical or helping context

Reflect accurately and resist over-interpreting. — "It sounds like the tiredness is the thing that's hardest to manage."

Someone venting who doesn't want solutions

Reflect and stop — don't slide into advice. — "So you don't need this fixed, you just need it heard."

A text or message thread

Keep the reflection to one line so it doesn't read as heavy. — "Sounds like the frustrating part was the lack of warning."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person needs urgent action, not reflection
- You are guessing too far beyond the evidence
- Reflection would sound patronising
- They have asked for a direct answer
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the moment

List three real conversations from the past week where reflecting the core would have helped. For each, note the one sentence that carried the real point.

Day 2 — Write the ladder

For each situation, write a weak line, a better line, and the best line — specific, tentative and grounded.

Day 3 — Shorten it

Say each best line aloud twice, then cut it by about a third. Keep only the words that name the point.

Day 4 — Kill the therapy-speak

Rewrite any line that sounds clinical or scripted into plain, ordinary speech you'd actually use out loud.

Day 5 — Field-test the minimum move

In one low-stakes conversation, use a single one-line reflection and note how the other person responds.

Day 6 — Calibrate and release

In a real conversation, reflect once, then watch the cues. If they shorten or tense up, drop the technique and follow them instead.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Deliberately guess slightly wrong, use a recovery line, and let them correct you. Notice how the correction sharpens the conversation.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I identify the right conversational moment?
- Did I use plain, ordinary language rather than clinical phrasing?
- Did I keep the other person's autonomy intact — leaving room to correct me?
- Did I stop after one move instead of overusing the technique?
- Did I use a recovery line if the reflection missed?
- Did the technique make the conversation easier rather than more self-conscious?